MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 2: Poetry - Historical Development

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Poetry moves through overlapping traditions of lyric, epic, neoclassical wit, satire, and heightened attention to feeling, nature, and imagination.

Start with a picture

A musical programme can include a solo song, a long dramatic work, and a witty parody. Their differences involve form and purpose, not a ladder from primitive to advanced art.

1. Caroline lyric

Poets associated with the reign of Charles I often cultivate song, love, pleasure, loyalty, and finely made short forms. Herrick, Lovelace, Carew, and Suckling provide examples. The group is varied; a courtly association does not settle every poem’s meaning.

2. Milton and epic

Milton’s Paradise Lost combines biblical subject matter with classical epic resources. Blank verse, extended similes, invocations, and an elevated narrative voice give the poem scale. The grand style involves syntax and intellectual range as well as impressive vocabulary.

Blank verse is unrhymed iambic pentameter. It can sustain varied sentence rhythms across line endings, a resource different from the closure of a rhyming couplet.

3. Neoclassicism

Neoclassical writers value craft, proportion, decorum, inherited models, and critical judgement. They adapt classical forms to their own debates. The term does not mean that every poem is unemotional or that all writers obey identical rules.

Decorum concerns the relationship between style, speaker, genre, and subject. A deliberate mismatch can become a powerful satirical method.

4. Heroic couplet

A heroic couplet pairs rhyming lines of iambic pentameter. Balance, antithesis, and concentrated wit can give an argument force. Dryden and Pope use the form with different energies and degrees of syntactic closure.

A couplet is not just any two lines that happen to rhyme; metre and function matter in this historical usage.

5. Mock epic

Mock epic applies elevated conventions to a subject whose scale creates a satirical mismatch. Mac Flecknoe turns succession into a ceremony of dullness; The Rape of the Lock magnifies fashionable conflict through epic machinery.

The smaller subject is not necessarily ethically insignificant. Inflation can expose a society's distorted values while also drawing attention to genuine injury or inequality.

6. Transition and pre-Romantic tendencies

Interest in song, sensibility, landscape, mortality, and imaginative freedom grows within the century's varied writing. Burns and Blake challenge a rigid account of the period as nothing but polished rationalism. They draw on traditions even while revising their uses.

Period labels overlap. A new emphasis does not arrive on one morning and erase older forms.

Quick check

1. Does blank verse rhyme? **No; it has a metrical basis.**
2. What makes mock epic work? **A meaningful mismatch between elevated conventions and the subject.**
3. Is neoclassicism equivalent to absence of feeling? **No.**

Build an exam answer

1. Explain form as an organising resource.
2. Use Milton's blank verse and epic scale.
3. Discuss heroic couplets and judgement.
4. Analyse mock-epic mismatch.
5. Qualify the transition to feeling and song.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not describe eighteenth-century poetry as uniformly cold or use grand style as a synonym for difficult words.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Discuss the relationship between poetic form and changing values across the period.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The period contains different ways of giving thought an artistic shape. Milton’s blank verse supports large syntactic movements and the scale of biblical epic. Its grandeur cannot be reduced to ornament: the form helps the narrator connect action with theological and moral argument. A close reading should attend to how sentences move through lines as well as what they describe.

The heroic couplet creates other possibilities. Rhyme, balance, and antithesis can make judgement memorable and expose a contradiction with concentrated force. Mock epic depends on another formal relation, the deliberate transfer of elevated machinery to a setting where the mismatch becomes critical.

Later and overlapping tendencies towards song, feeling, and imagination do not require a complete rejection of craft. Burns’s musical stanza and Blake’s apparently simple lyric forms are highly organised. Their emotional immediacy is produced through formal choices rather than opposed to them.

An effective answer therefore avoids a binary between an age of reason and an age of emotion. It traces how different forms make different values and speaking positions possible, using specific poems as evidence. Continuity and experimentation belong together in that history.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Discuss the key features and poets of the Age of Transition.
2. Write a short note on heroic couplets in poetry.
3. Analyse the contribution of Jonathan Swift, Alexander Pope and John Dryden to satiric poetry.
4. What are the characteristics of the Neoclassical Age?
5. Explain the poetic career and style of John Milton.